

I'm lonely. And I'm just like, why are you not talking to each other? And then the thing was, we don't know how. Boys can go to war for each other, but they don't know how to cry in front of each other. And that was what kind of became the impetus. We have to do something from a pop culture lens to be able to tell these boys that it is okay.

Why a podcast? Why not a documentary or a limited series?

Nikhil: My background has been fiction. But the thing that I realised in all the campuses was that more than someone to talk to, they need someone who would listen to them. In any piece of content that I make, I can only entertain. I can probably inform. But I can't make it clear how important it is to listen. In every college I would ask, why don't you talk to somebody when there's something going on in your life, you're overwhelmed, you're anxious? And the answer was that they would judge. And then I would ask them, how do you know that they would judge you? And the answer after introspection would be, because we do it too. So I've been a little left-of-centre podcaster, where my podcast is not necessarily about two men talking. It is actually like me just listening. Every time I've had to give a speech, I've just been like, I'm not getting this for being a podcaster who talks. I'm getting this because I've been trying to tell the world that it is important to listen. And listening could not have happened in any other medium.

How do you prepare and make your podcast a safe space?

Nikhil: For every episode I do, I spend about three to four days at a minimum listening to every conversation that the person on this podcast is coming to have. When I was speaking to Javed Akhtar, I read two of his books. A book of conversations that he's done. I also have a very strong research team that does a lot of this. I try to ask questions

that nobody has asked them. And that's where conversations like Bhuvan Bam come out. Because I've heard every podcast of his, I knew that he doesn't smoke or drink. So in the unboxing, there were those phantom cigarettes, and he started chewing them. I said, okay, but why do you not smoke? Explain why. And then he just happened to say, when you open a bottle of liquor at home every night. And then I just paused a little bit. I was like, is it okay if I ask you

You cannot just call any guest on your podcast. You cannot have anybody who has any random thing to say which is contradictory to truth, to morality, to our value systems. Words and ideas have the power to change the world. That's what Robin Williams said in Dead Poets Society. We need to check ourselves as podcasters and ask who are we platforming?

more about this? What do you mean, at home? And then in that conversation he spoke for the first time in his life about his father's alcoholism. He had these best friends from childhood, people he'd been together with for 20 years. I asked him, how much of this do they know? And he was like, they'll be hearing this for the first time in their life. It wouldn't have happened had I not known that he doesn't smoke or drink, and not had the curiosity to understand why.

What role does technology play in making or breaking a podcast?

Nikhil: What tech has done is it has made everything democratic. The

moment you have an internet connection, a phone with a decent camera, and just a friend who's there to help you, you can do it. Now you can get a phone with a great camera for as little as 13,000, and then you just need an internet connection, which again, after Jio, has become the easiest thing to have. You have to come to either Bombay or Delhi, you have to work in a channel or in a production house, and then you get the opportunity at some day in your future to be in front of a camera. But today you don't need that. The flip side is, the cheaper the technology has gotten, the more saturated this medium has become. And now everybody who may not necessarily have anything to say also has become a podcaster. I feel like there are more podcasters than there are listeners.

One piece of advice you would give to someone starting their podcasting journey in 2026?

Nikhil: First you need to figure out who you are. You literally need to introspect and figure out how your voice is adding to the conversation and not to the noise. Are you saying something just because you need to say something, or are you saying something because it needs to be said? And if you don't say it, is it something that a million other people will say, or is it something that nobody else will be able to say? Even if you're trying to make a podcast about phones, or about Funko Pops, you need to be someone who just cares the most deeply about the topic you pick. If you don't care deeply about it, people will catch on to your bullshit. This is where exactly your authenticity matters a lot in a medium where you're literally in somebody's ear. It doesn't matter how niche your topic of passion is, as long as you love it to death. Your love is what's going to travel to other people who are just like you. **[E]**